

Living together

Some animals spend most of their lives on their own and only get together to mate. Many species, however, are social animals that reap the benefits of gathering together in large flocks, herds, or shoals. Life in a group is usually safer, and it can help animals to find more food. A few species live in highly organized societies called colonies, where members depend on each other to survive. Most of these animals are social insects, such as ants, wasps, and bees, which form giant family groups. These are often ruled by a single breeding female—the queen.

Social insects

Termites live in enormous colonies of up to 25 million members—the offspring of a single queen and a breeding male, or king. In a termite nest, individual insects work together to feed and protect the colony. The termites are divided into different ranks called castes, which perform different roles within the group.



Giving birth

With its huge sausage-shaped abdomen, a queen termite lays several thousand eggs a day. Workers feed the queen and carry her eggs to the nursery.



Caring for the young

Once the eggs have hatched, workers rear the young termites, or nymphs, in dedicated nursery areas constructed deep inside the termite nest.



Fungus farming

Some workers build underground compost heaps from their own droppings. They farm the fungus that grows on the compost and use it as food for the colony.



Defending the colony

Soldier termites protect the nest. Some are armed with powerful jaws that bite, while others squirt toxic liquids or release a glue-like substance against enemies.

Swarm clusters around queen bee



Matriarch leads herd to water



Flying the nest

When a beehive gets overcrowded, the queen bee leaves, taking a large group of workers with her. Here, a swarm of honeybees has settled on a branch, while scout bees inspect possible new nesting sites for the colony. When a scout returns after finding a good site, it dances on the surface of the swarm, encouraging others to investigate its find. Once the majority of scouts agree on a new location, the entire swarm moves to its new home.



Penguin parade

Huddled together on a rocky beach, groups of adult king penguins form a stark contrast with their fluffy brown chicks. During the breeding season, as many as 100,000 adult pairs gather in huge colonies on the islands off the coast of Antarctica. These crowded breeding sites are sheltered from the snow and ice and some have been used by penguins for centuries.